

This week is **פרשת צו**, which is **שבת הגדול**, the great **שבת** before our wonderful **יום טוב** of **פסח**. **שבת הגדול** is called by this name for many reasons. One reason is that **לדור דורות** the **דרשה** on the **הלכות** of **פסח** was given on this **שבת**. Since it was a major **דרשה**, it became known as **שבת הגדול**. Another reason is that on this day, **בני ישראל** were commanded to take the **שה**, tie it to the bedpost, and prepare it as the **פסח**. This was a great **נס**.

What was the **נס**? The **נס** was that the **מצריים** didn't react. **משה רבינו** had protested to Hashem, saying, "**בני ישראל** can't do this! The **שה** is **מצרים**'s **עבודה זרה**, and they will kill us!" Hashem responded, "**חייך** - I swear, they are not leaving **מצרים** until they do exactly that." Now, within the great panoply of **מכות**, **גיסים**, and the entire story of **יציאת מצרים**, tying a **שעפסל** to the bedpost seems like a rather minor detail, yet we call it **שבת הגדול**. What is the underlying message here?

We can gain some insight into what **הקדוש ברוך הוא** considers to be **גדול**, and how we should orient ourselves by looking at another instance where the word **גדול** is used. Where do we find this? At **קריעת ים סוף**, which took place at the end of **פסח**. What does the **פסוק** which we recite every day in davening, say? **וַיֵּרָא יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַיָּד הַגְּדֹלָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה ה' בְּמִצְרַיִם** - They witnessed the great hand of Hashem, in that which he did to **מצרים**. This is written immediately after **ים סוף**. **קריעת ים סוף**.

The Lutzker Rav, the **אזנים לתורה**, asks an important question. There were two aspects to **ים סוף**. The first was the incredible **נס** of the sea splitting, allowing **בני ישראל** to cross, a once-in-history event. The second was that, while **בני ישראל** were still crossing, the sea returned to its place, drowning the **מצריים**. The question is: which of these two events is referred to as the **הגדולה**?

The answer is that it refers not to the splitting of the sea, but to the drowning of the **מצריים**. **בני ישראל** witnessed the **השם**, **יד**, not just in the supernatural event of the sea splitting, but in what seemed to be a natural occurrence - the water returning to its place. They were able to experience, realize, and internalize that **הקדוש ברוך הוא** runs the world, even in the mundane forces of nature, such as gravity.

This is what **גדולה** truly is. **גדולה** is recognizing **השם אחד ושמו אחד** and living with the awareness of **שְׁוִיָּתִי ה'**. We must realize that Hashem is constantly with us - no matter what we are doing, no matter how we act. **גדולה** is present in every moment, in every step we take, in every breath we breathe. We must appreciate this and keep it in mind as we navigate our daily routines and the challenges that **הזה** presents. All of these difficulties and stresses are designed to help us learn more and more about Hashem's **חסד** and His **הנהגה** in the world - to recognize that Hashem is the **מנהיג העולם**. One crucial lesson we should take from **פסח** is that Hashem's involvement in the world is not a one-time event but an ongoing reality.

An additional point to mention, since we are in **פרשת צו** and can't overlook it. The **קרבת תודה** is mentioned in **פרשת צו**. As we know, the **תודה** is a **קרבת** brought for many reasons. The **גמרא** lists four specific cases in which a person brings a **תודה**: someone who traveled across the ocean, someone who traveled through the **מדבר**, someone who was sick and recovered, and someone who was in the **בית הסורים** and was released.

All of these situations involve **ישועות** from Hashem, and they warrant bringing a **תודה**. It's important for us to keep this in mind as well. Every day, except for **שבת**, we say **תודה** in our **תפילה**. Why don't we say it on **שבת**? Because the **קרבת תודה** could not be brought on **שבת**. Interestingly, it also could not be brought on **פסח**, since it was offered together with **לחם חמץ**.

Both **שבת** and **פסח** are paradigms of **הכרת הטוב**. **שבת** is the great gift of Hashem - an island of serenity in our pressured work week. As we approach **פסח**, we have to remember to constantly say, "Thank you, thank you, thank you," all day long, for all of the **חסד** that Hashem does for us. One of the most powerful



examples of *הכרת הטוב* in the *תורה* is found in the story of *יציאת מצרים* in *רש"י*. *פרשת בשלה*, explains that when the *פסוק* says *וְהָמָשִׁים עָלוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרָיִם*, it means that *בני ישראל* left *מצרים* armed. If they were armed, why was it necessary for *הקדוש ברוך הוא* to perform the extraordinary *נס* of *ים סוף*? Why didn't *בני ישראל* simply turn around and fight off the *מצריים* who were pursuing them?

The *סופר* answers this question with a remarkable insight. The *הכרת הטוב* that *בני ישראל* owed to the *מצריים* prevented them from fighting against them. This is astounding. After all the years of suffering, oppression, and cruelty - after the *מצריים* had murdered their children and forced them into unbearable labor - still, the *תורה* teaches us that *ישראל* remained bound by a sense of *הכרת הטוב*. Why? Because, despite everything, *מצרים* had originally welcomed them as guests and had provided them with a place to live.

This shows us the depth to which *הכרת הטוב* must extend. *הקדוש ברוך הוא* had to perform the *נס* of *ים סוף* specifically so that *ישראל* would not have to engage in battle against *מצרים*. *בעזרת השם*, in the merit of expressing gratitude - both to Hashem and to others - may we continue to receive *ברכה* and *הצלחה*. May Hashem continue to shower us with His kindness, and may we soon merit to see the *גאולה שלמה* with the coming of *משיח צדקנו*, *במהרה בימינו*.

